

Mean Age at Marriage by Ethnic group

Table 9.11 shows the mean age at marriage by ethnic group as reported in the Census of Population and Housing 2024.

Table 9.11 : Mean Age at Marriage by Ethnic Group, 2024

Ethnic group	Male (Years)	Female (Years)
Sinhalese	29.5	26.1
Sri Lanka Tamil	29.0	25.1
Indian Tamil/Malaiyaga Thamilar	28.5	24.7
Sri Lanka Moor/Muslim	27.2	23.4
Other*	29.5	25.9

*Others – This category includes Burgher, Malay, Sri Lanka Chetty, Bharata, Vedda, and other specified ethnic groups.

The lowest mean age at marriage for both males and females are reported among the Sri Lanka Moor/Muslim ethnic group. The highest mean age at marriage is reported among the Sinhalese and other ethnic groups for males, and among the Sinhalese ethnic group when considering females.

9.3 Fertility

Fertility refers to the number of live births given by a woman of reproductive age (15–49 years) during a specified period. It is a key demographic indicator. Fertility indicators provide important insights into population growth, future population trends, and socio-economic planning in a country. These measures facilitate the analysis of reproductive patterns among women, the requirements for education and health services, the prospective size of the labour force, and the process of population ageing. In addition, fertility measures are essential for assessing family planning programs, making regional and temporal comparisons, and monitoring progress towards the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Concepts and Definitions

To prepare national and regional fertility indicators, information on live births was collected from ever-married females aged 15 years and over during the Census of Population and Housing 2024. Accordingly, all ever-married females aged 15 years and over were asked whether they had ever given a live birth, the total number of live births they had, and the number of boys and girls separately. In addition, data were collected on the number of children alive at the time of the census and the year and month of the last birth.

Table 9.12 shows the percentage distribution of live births among ever-married females aged 15-49 years in the urban, rural, and Estate Rural sectors, according to the Census of Population and Housing 2024.

Table 9.12 : Percentage Distribution of Ever-Married Women Aged 15 Years and Over by the Number of Live Births per Woman and Sector, 2024

Sector	Number of Ever-Married Women Aged 15 Years and Over	Percentage of women by number of Live Births								
		Total	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7+
All Sectors	6,977,254	100.0	10.6	19.0	33.3	22.4	8.1	3.4	1.6	1.6
Urban*	1,207,941	100.0	12.9	21.3	34.0	19.9	6.9	2.7	1.2	1.1
Rural	5,504,477	100.0	10.0	18.7	33.4	22.6	8.2	3.5	1.6	1.8
Estate Rural **	264,836	100.0	12.4	16.0	26.2	28.3	10.7	3.8	1.4	1.2

* In 2024 information was collected separately for "Urban" and "Estate Urban" sectors, for comparison with the 2012 Census data, these two sectors have been combined and presented as "Urban".

** In the 2012 Census, the sector was identified as "Estate", whereas in the 2024 Census it is referred to as "Estate Rural."